This shadow puppet theatre is staged over a vast, rolling rural continuum whose stunted economy mirrors its bonsai democracy. Bonhomie fills the fan-cooled *baithaki* of the pradhan's house in Bhishampur, near Chakia. It's a relatively prosperous village—pucca houses and shops in the main street—and its whole concourse of castes is represented here, mostly from UP's Other Backward Classes (OBC) spectrum: Yadav, Kushwaha, Lohar, Bind, Mallah, Nonia Chauhan et al. But the best line on intra-OBC dynamics was spoken by a shepherd on the hill-fringed pastures outside. Chandrika Pal, tall and majestic around his grazing flock, is a Gadariya—his political nemesis is just down the road, a Yadav with his buffaloes, any day a more powerful claimant for these commons. "*Yadav ki laat toh sirf bhains hi sah sakti hai* (Only a buffalo can bear the kick of a Yadav)," he grins.

Brahmin Angst

Mud houses with sloping tile roofs start dominating the visual field—and occasional references to Maoism begin to pop up—as the miles stretch closer to Naugarh, the only other town before Robertsganj. A small gaggle of hutments along a cut to the right is rich in grievance and dirt-poor in life choices: a mix of Dalit castes resides here. But equally resigned to a stagnant fate is the famous Thakur habitat across the fields. Babhora is Union defence minister Rajnath Singh's native village, and a stroll through it outright dispels any thoughts of favouritism. Questions are redundant. "*Aap khud hi dekh lijiye* (please see for yourself)," says a chubby youth in bermudas and chappals, standing amidst decrepitude and dung-smeared mud walls, his nasal tone and Bhojpuri lilt naturally sardonic. The only gift of fame is a CRPF training centre nearby. Back on the road, before the road climbs into the forested Kaimurs, a shrine under a giant banyan hosts a Pasi wedding rite. They stay away from everyone else.

Deep in the hills, at Jamsoti, a resort offers deluxe eco cottages. Past its gate, in his own cottage, the first in a sweep of mud architecture, Surender Kol is the rare man content luxuriating in the benefits of being a *labharthi* (beneficiary). "There's no water, though," he says, a new BSNL tower looming in the middle distance. Past a wooded stretch punctuated by Adivasi hamlets, and Naugarh (a smaller, more rustic cousin of Chakia), there finally comes the broken townscape of Robertsganj, the district HQ. Nehru had called Sonbhadra the "Switzerland of India", but Robertsganj is no Lausanne. Named for a colonial general, it's quite the urban correlate of the rural dystopia surrounding it. For a mineral-rich district with perhaps India's maximum concentration of power plants, the distribution of power among the people is thin. Democracy suffers from transmission and distribution losses.

COUNTDOWN
Subhash Kharwar, a shop owner in Chakia, is pro-caste census. Kharwars straddle the caste-tribe continuum here: they are SC in Chandauli, ST in Sonbhadra, within the same constituency



All parties follow a path that favours a token form of representation. "The Dalit vote is rendered even more irrelevant in reserved seats," says Yogendra Yadav

The disempowerment flows across all strata, albeit at vastly different levels. In Sehuan, a Brahmin-dominated village, the built heritage is the old mix of feudal comfort and privation—both sunk in a morass of benign neglect, a new road easing it of late. Ratnesh Pandey, the pradhan's father, voices the common anger here against Pakaudi Lal. "*Is baar dekhenge* (let's see this time)," he muses—a layer of the old saffron vote on the verge of flaking off. Outside of politics, their litany of complaints is the same as everyone else's: the State doesn't come visiting.